

GAMEMASTER: IS IT YOU?

Alfred C. Snider

*Embracing the goddess energy within yourselves
Will bring all of you to a new understanding and valuing of life,
A vision that inspires you to live and love on planet Earth.*

*Like a bright jewel buried in dark layers of soil and stone,
Earth radiates her brilliant beauty into the caverns of space and time.*

*Perhaps you are aware of those who watch over your home
And experience it as a place to visit and play with reality.
You are becoming aware of yourself as a gamemaster.*

-Lost Tribe, "Gamemaster," Tranceport CD

Twenty years is not such a long time, comparatively. However, the anniversary of my original publications about gaming as a paradigm for academic debate does seem like an opportune moment to evaluate the basis and progress of academic debating as well as the paradigm I have written about for it. This is not to say that gaming has been a "hot button" issue for academic debate during the last two decades, or that its use and defense has been played out in debate rounds many times. The sheer invisibility of gaming has actually been one of its strengths. This paradigm was utilized (knowingly or unknowingly) by the majority of American debate teams and judges during this period. It has not been argued about inside of the debates themselves because it is not a strategic tool – it grants advantage to neither side in the debate. However, there are stirrings that debating in America has changed, that the old game is over, and that we need to "step outside of the box" of gaming as a paradigm for academic debate. The explosion of debate in new communities and in

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many, many nations also may strain the influence that the gaming concept has on this dynamic activity.

My purpose here is to review recent competitive American debate history, consider how gaming has operated within that framework, and address the relevance of gaming to a number of the so-called challenges facing modern academic debating in America and now beyond. The game of debate as a theoretical approach becomes merged with the reality of competitive academic debate in this essay. I write as a debate teacher, coach, and practitioner for over thirty years. I have trodden the dusty paths, driven the all-night vans, sought for lost luggage, struggled with language translations, engaged in the act of debate strategizing, expressed anguish because of the behavior of judges, watched countless students bloom, and more that I will not attempt to share. The “young rebel” of gaming is now the “elder coach” who is asked to write a twentieth anniversary essay for a leading journal. In such a situation I ask for your understanding, as I may be somewhat less than formal and fully “academic.” I desire to be brief so as to leave space for my distinguished respondents.

Initial Misunderstandings

There were brief and tentative criticisms of gaming initially. Some said that debate was too important to be “just” a game. It did not occur to these persons that games could be important. Perhaps they had never seen the World Cup. Others indicated that the fantasy involved in the other paradigms (policy making and hypothesis testing were used as examples) was necessary for proper training and the integrity of the activity while failing to recognize the obvious limits of these fantasy roles as explanatory while neglecting the integral “gaming” features of the activity as practiced.

The most serious error in reacting to gaming has been mistaking decision rules for paradigms. A paradigm is a “Weltanschauung,” or “world view” of a given individual. A “model of models,” a paradigm organizes our behaviors within academic debate by giving metaphoric guidance (Snider, 1982, pp. 9-10). A decision rule is the “accounting system” of the game. This is a factual representation of some real world process at an acceptable level of detail for use in the context of the gestalt of the game. In debate, this would be thought of as issues of quantity/quality and/or outcome/process. In their advocacy for or against the scenario/topic being debated, teams may claim that their positions lead to a better quantity/quality or a better outcome/process (Snider, 1982, p. 154).

The gaming paradigm as spelled out properly locates these pre-gaming paradigms within the gaming context as decision rules. A debate taking place under an assumed paradigm of policy making will proceed to decision along certain decision pathways and formulas. The model of public policy making guides the decision in the debate without being explanatory enough to be a true paradigm. The point most often missed is that most so-called paradigms are assimilated by gaming and accounted for as decision rules (Snider, 1991). This error has continued.

Silent Adoption

The gaming paradigm was never a construct that was forced onto the actual procedures of debating. Rather, gaming serves as an explanatory paradigm that should be utilized because it fits debate as it is and helps us understand how the actuality of debate operates. Academic competitive debate was already a game before my articles appeared. My articles merely served to explain what debating had become. Thus, the “adoption” of gaming as a paradigm was mostly silent, as debaters, judges, and tournament directors continued to do what they had been doing already.

The Game Of Debate And Three Challenges

In the last twenty years new issues and new challenges have arisen. I will attempt to discuss some of these issues and then relate them to the gaming paradigm. I view these as important issues that need to be seriously considered in order for academic competitive debating to thrive in the years to come. Although not providing a clear prescription for these challenges, gaming does provide some insight. I invite my respondents in this issue to give their own learned options about these challenges.

One: Stepping Out Of The Box

I take this phrase from Ede Warner of the University of Louisville. In judging an elimination debate between Kansas and Vermont at CEDA Nationals Ede commented after the round that the debate was proceeding down predictable policy pathways when all of a sudden the Vermont team “stepped out of the box” and called for a decision based on the discourse and framework advocated by Kansas. He explained that the normal procedures of the game had been shifted away from a discussion of policy outcomes to a discussion of discourse and frameworks. This example heralds what has become a very hot issue in

modern competitive academic debate on policy topics: the call for alternatives to the traditional decision rule (see eDebate Listserv, 2002).

To explain what is meant by this traditional policy approach, it might be wise to quote one of its major advocates, Stefan Bauschard. This is how Bauschard defines his conception of what teams should do at his decidedly “within the box” Policy Debate Round Robin Tournament (Bauschard, 2002):

...we define policy debate as a willingness of the affirmative to advance a specific traditional/fiated plan that they will advocate as being net-beneficial relative to the status quo or a specific alternative. Negatives are responsible for defending the status quo or specific alternative(s) in the form of a traditional counterplan as being net-beneficial relative to the affirmative plan. <http://ndtceda.com/archives/200212/0185.html>]

What happens when a team decides to “step out of the box?” There are an infinite number of alternatives, certainly, but several seem to dominate. The traditional decision rule of policy making is rejected and an alternative proposed. At times the team introducing a new decision rule will call for an evaluation of the discourse in the debate. Arguing that the imaginary policies to be adopted by fiat are less real than the discourse that proceeds from the mouths of the debaters, the team proposes that the judge evaluate the discourse for its appropriateness. For example, a team may have used offensive language (sexist, racist) or marginalizing language (“third world,” or “underdeveloped”) and the other team may call for the decision based on this objectionable discourse. In a slightly different approach, a team may provide a different form of “performance” (it might include narratives, drama, poetry, song, music, etc.) and call for the decision in the debate based on a comparison of their exciting and illuminating performance with the more pedestrian performance of the opposing team. In another approach one team might advocate a “real world” “project” that they are involved in, usually linked to the resolution, but that attempts to change the views of those in the debate as well as others in the debate community about some specific approach to an issue, perhaps using a different form of analysis such as engaging in a genealogy or a historical investigation. The team “stepping out of the box” calls for an affiliation by the judge with their “project” by arguing that it is a real political move and not just a way to win the debate. Of course, it is almost always still an attempt to win the debate.

The dance of argument going on inside the game may be different, but it is still inside the game. Introducing the decision rules of discourse, performance, or project to substitute for the definition supplied earlier does not stop all of these events from being competitive academic debates within the gaming construct. The ability to introduce new decision rules to reflect changing times and academic interests is a vast strength of academic debate as a game, because it is flexible and adaptable to the intellectual community expressing themselves through it. As one who loves to read old debate textbooks and hear about debate practices from forty or fifty years ago, I can assure you that I have no desire to return to those decision rules or even those from “when giants walked the earth” (read as “when I debated”). When old debaters come back and find things very much changed, I do not despair along with them since it makes me feel positive about the activity and its progress.

These new ways to conceptualize the debate, and those yet to come, are welcome changes and signs of growth and vitality. However, any approach to debate can lead to a poorly crafted and unpleasant performance, especially when new thoughts are finding their way. The challenge is to theorize, utilize, and criticize these new approaches while recognizing that they are decision rules, and analyzing them as such may assist us in creating standards for evaluating “projects” and “performances” once they have been placed in the proper context for the debater and the judge.

The current critical move in American competitive policy debate exists along with traditional policy debate practices. Sometimes the debate will proceed along one path or the other, at other times the debate will involve a head on collision between these two approaches to debate, and at other times entirely new and different decision rules will be introduced. But, they will be decision rules, not paradigms. The game is still afoot. Despair not and feel free to support the kind of debate you feel is best while maintaining a respectful willingness to listen and consider alternatives.

Two: Debate As Process

Traditionally debate was seen as an excellent educational tool, and talented students were encouraged to use debate to hone their skills and prepare them for leadership. At least, that is always what I was told. In the 1990s that tune was to change just a bit. Instead of just for “some” of the “better” students, debate increasingly came to be seen by many as a way of giving previously silenced student populations a chance to develop and exercise their “voice.” If debate skills were the critical entry skill to the higher levels of social

achievement, then certainly it could assist people everywhere in becoming more than they would otherwise. Some conceived of debate as a method for empowerment.

The urban debate leagues are an important example of debate outreach to new communities. These leagues were established by the Open Society Institute in cooperation with Emory University originally, and ultimately with major educational institutions and community groups in metropolitan areas all over America. The idea was to create debate teams in academically challenged schools. Not every school and not every city program has been a success, but fourteen cities, 221 high schools, and 40 middle schools later we have 12,000 competitive debaters and 700 trained teachers who are their own best testimony (NAUDL, 2002). [NAUDL Fact Sheet, November 2002]. The urban debate league movement has received the attention of CBS' Sixty Minutes and many major newspapers and magazines (Morris, 2002; Bahrapour, 2000; Keoun, 2000; Gherzi, 2002; Ervin, 2001; Ruenzel, 2002). Other leagues, in places like Massachusetts and Alabama, have started and flourished even without funding from the Open Society Institute. Programs based on the example of the urban debate leagues have begun in places like London [Tesco London Debate Programme of the English Speaking Union] and Santiago, Chile [Torneo Interscolar Academico Metropolitano of Universidad Diego Portales], taking debate directly and immediately to students in disadvantaged academic environments. The National Association of Urban Debate Leagues (<http://www.urbandebate.org/>) has now formally affiliated with the National Forensic League (<http://debate.uvm.edu/nfl.html>) thanks to the cooperation of NAUDL's Les Lynn and NFL's James Copeland.

Urban debate league advocates have seen the debate "process" as a method for empowerment. During this exercise in grafting debate onto current challenged educational systems another aspect of the debate "process" has manifested itself, the debate across the curriculum concept. Urban debate leagues working with school districts and principals have been the earliest advocates of debate across the curriculum (DAC). Urban debate league teachers have been the shock troops of testing the concept of using debate to teach just about anything. Their support and enthusiasm led to the publication by Maxwell Schnurer and me of a DAC book for teachers (Snider & Schnurer, 2002). This slim volume is currently being translated into Russian, Spanish, Mongolian, and Rumanian. Exciting developments in various school districts herald a rising use of debate as teaching tool for history, literature, culture, politics, social sciences, and others. The real progress of these efforts, however, takes place one classroom at a time as teachers look for new and exciting ways to teach

students about normal subjects in a way that is active, communicative, and develops critical thinking. The debate across the curriculum concept presents a further challenge to the original logic of debate (teach the gifted the super skills of leadership) as well as the original logic of urban debate league proponents (teach critical debate skills to students for whom it can make a huge difference) by arguing that if debate as a process is so valuable then it should be available to everyone and should be strongly integrated into normal classroom practice.

Debate, at its flexible best, provides a strong framework for the advancement of these goals, operating as a critical discourse game. Debates can be designed and arranged to pursue different sorts of goals in classrooms and communities. Debate appears not so much as a formalized disputation and communicative processes but rather as a flexible critical discourse game that attempts to attract and attune students and teachers precisely because it is critical and engaging, because it is participative and expresses ideas from the students, and because it is somewhat competitive and strongly socially engaging as a flexible game of intellect and expression.

One danger in abandoning a specific niche for debate is that if it is everywhere, then there do not need to be centers of focus for debate. If debate is in every class, this may make it more difficult to promote a class in debate. If something is everywhere, it is easier for us all of a sudden to find it nowhere.

How can gaming guide us? It is important to remember that the game of debate is at its best when it is adapted to the needs of the participants. When it is bogged down by restrictive formats that no longer make sense in new settings, its potential is often lost. We have seen how the changes around us have influenced the changes of approach in policy debate. It is not surprising that different situations call for different models of debate. In some situations debate occurs in youth clubs, not in schools. In others it is a class activity, or an extra curricular activity, or a formal sport of the mind. There are one person and six person "teams." There are long and short debate formats. Some topics are spontaneous; some prepared before a tournament, and some a yearlong focus for an entire national debating community. The balance given to criteria such as public speaking, persuasion, research, strategy, level of knowledge, endurance, and other factors should be based on what those participating need and want. The public "freshers debate" I saw at the Oxford Union, the cloning debate I saw high in the mountains of Serbia, the final round of the first Korean

university national championship I witnessed, the debate between eleven-year-olds on whether pregnant girls should go to different schools I watched in a dirt floor school house in Chile while the rooster in the attached chicken coop crowed, the final round of Lincoln Douglas debate at the National Forensic League national tournament, and the debate held at a middle school about the pros and cons of joining a gang are very, very different, as they should be for so many different settings, audiences, and purposes. The critical discourse game brings its exciting elements to the task of education and empowerment, and it will not be seriously threatened by creating formats that seem appropriate for the situation at hand.

Three: Debate As Global

America has never had a monopoly on debating, although American debaters and coaches often act that way. The United Kingdom and many Commonwealth nations have a much longer history of debating as an educational and competitive activity. Many other nations had debate practices as an integral part of their intellectual traditions even if there were differences with British and American practice. Robert Branham, always a powerful and unique debate theorist, was one of the first to document debate traditions in other nations. (Branham, 1991) Just as he resurrected, for the American audience at least, the experience of Malcolm X learning to debate in prison, he did the same with the debate traditions of China, Japan, and India.

In the 1990s one important barrier to free debate practices came tumbling down – the barrier between Communist and western prosperous nations. Just as he had done through the sponsorship of urban debate leagues through the Open Society Institute, George Soros promoted his vision of “open societies” by sponsoring debate activities. These grants and organizational efforts gave rise to the International Debate Education Association (<http://www.idebate.org>), a membership organization designed to promote debating exchanges and debating in individual nations in a number of languages. English was always encouraged as a debating language because it is the world’s most popular second language, and because when country A debates country B the most compatible language will be English. Now in its 6th year, IDEA is made up of 27 countries with over 60,000 secondary (high school) students, 10,000 University students and 13,000 teachers.

The English Speaking Union (<http://www.esu.org/educate/centre>) is an international charity based in London. Its Centre for Speech and Debate has promoted public speaking and debate activities in 51 branch nations. It coordinates much of British debating and is

strongly supportive of the two major international tournaments that reflect British debating conventions, the World Universities Debating Championship and the World Schools Debating Championship. These tournaments are held annually and move their locations round the world. They are well attended and extremely prestigious. Activities of the English Speaking Union related to debating have increased at the turn of the century under the leadership of Lord Watson of Richmond, Marc Whitmore, and Debbie Newman. Outreach activities continue to expand debating. Latin Americans are beginning to organize on their own in places like Chile, Nicaragua, Venezuela, Puerto Rico and others. They have held two international Spanish language debate championships, and Chile has won both titles. Meanwhile, China has agreed to host a ten-day debate institute for university students in August 2003 after several years of planning and development.

Debaters are debating in increasing numbers all over the world. However, the barriers of distance have kept them from debating on a more global basis. Occasional international tournaments do take place, but for the most part travel costs keep debaters from international competition. This tyranny of distance may be partially dissolved by the use of Internet technology. Streaming video could make it possible for teams to see and hear their opponents on the other side of the world at a very low cost.

On Tuesday, December 23, 1999, at 10:00 AM Eastern Time, the world's first web cast distance debate was held. The topic was, "The United States should immediately lift all economic sanctions on Cuba." Cornell was affirmative and was represented by Anapurna Singh and Jethro Hayman. Helen Morgan and Sarah Jane Snider represented Vermont. The debate started on time and took a little over 60 minutes.

The first international Internet video debate (see short video at <http://debate.uvm.edu/debate.html>) was between the English Speaking Union in London and the University of Vermont. The event took place on March 14, 2000 at 1 PM Eastern Time, 1800 hours Greenwich Mean Time. The Vermont event featured greetings from Senator Patrick Leahy, Congressman Bernard Sanders, and Vermont Vice Provost Jane Lawrence. The London event featured Lord Watson, the head of Anderson Consulting UK, the UK Minister for E, as well as many other notables. The topic was, "The dinosaurs never see it coming: an exploration of the promises and perils of advanced technology." The focus of the proposition was that rapidly advancing technology threatens to render the unadaptive extinct.

The English Speaking Union and the University of Vermont have since staged a number of separate events. In addition, the Debate Central website (<http://debate.uvm.edu>) has web cast the final rounds of the Cross Examination Debate Association nationals, the National Debate Tournament, and both policy and Lincoln Douglas divisions at the National Forensic League. Marist College has joined the list of schools using this inexpensive method to web cast debate events. The role of this technology transcends even the question of international debating, which it certainly facilitates. It offers the possibility of dissolving the distance that divides debaters everywhere. It offers the possibility of creating a global debate community where every citizen can be a debater, every computer can be a global podium, and it all happens with delays of less than 10 seconds.

Format rigidity is a threat to the future development of international debating. The explosion of international debating and the technological ability to dissolve distance creates new challenges similar to those in the other areas discussed in this essay. Debaters who are too comfortable in their narrow boxes may be unwilling to step out of them. Those who are too wedded to the conventions of American policy debate, British parliamentary debate, or IDEA's Karl Popper debate will not be able to take advantage of the tremendous opportunities revealed by the new situation. Debate can be thought of as our intellectual food, and there are a delightful variety of ways to serve debate just as there are to serve food. Just as Britain has more curry shops than fish and chip shops, just as Chinese cooking has permeated every part of the USA, we must learn to appreciate the different international flavors of debating. Debate formats can be altered to meet different participant goals, even as the essence of the critical discourse game remains.

Just as organizational divisions have caused some consternation in national debate communities, the same could be true of organizational divisions in the international debate community. It is important for the major organizations to cooperate as opposed to attempting to establish hegemony, either stylistic or competitive. The game of debate belongs to everyone and should continue to exist in wide varieties. Debaters and teachers in every nation should prepare themselves to participate in other formats and even other languages. This is not easy, nor is it convenient, and it can be downright risky, but it is something that needs to be done as a service to the greater debate community of the future and to the participants in these new and exciting experiences.

Gaming can assist us conceptually in addressing this challenge because it recognizes difference as valuable and encourages an open platform in terms of style. My original work

in gaming describes debate as a “frame game,” in which we insert the content we want to address, fine tune the way in which it is enacted, enact the performance, evaluate the results, and then load and adjust again. This is the process we should be committed to. The bigoted and isolated “locker room talk” about certain debate traditions being “the only real debate” needs to be recognized for what it is.

Into The Future – The Next Twenty Years And Beyond

If one tries to be at all visionary it is dangerous to think that one can see very far ahead with much clarity. However, in order to get to a better place we need to direct ourselves towards it. Thus, with caution and misgivings, I offer some suggestions for those who are interested in this game of debate.

Broaden the Base

If debating has transformative power for individuals and societies, and I believe it does, then we make a serious error when we continue to serve it when it is an elite activity. I have nothing against the elite in general, but people who do not debate will not benefit from it. When asked my reaction to the six-person teams used in the Chilean university national championship, I said that the speeches should be longer and the number of debaters reduced to three. My host pointed out that this would cut by 50% the number of students benefiting from their debate experience. I constantly need to be reminded of this. It should no longer be a question of simply how high will our students rise, but how many will be lifted and the total distance covered.

Procedures over Rules

The game of debate operates very well as a relatively free wheeling communication event. Rules are required actions and systems, while procedures are generally accepted conventions (for a more complete discussion, see Snider, 1991). Twenty years ago I was convinced that academic debating advanced and evolved because of the predominance of procedures over rules. There will always be a finite number of rules, such as time limits, team compositions, topic, and others, but the game needs to be as open as possible. As ideas and consciousness change, as our vision of the world and our place in it evolves, the game of debate is able to adapt, change, and provide benefits if it is not overly restricted by complex rules. Besides, the rule-circumvention skills of debaters are legendary.

Each one Teach one

One of my interests is expanding debating and creating a climate where new schools, nations, communities are invited into the debate. My experience both in and out of major forensic organizations demonstrates to me that too much reliance on organizations to accomplish our evangelical goals can be a serious problem. The global debate community must not shunt efforts to help new groups join the debate on to organizations that are underfunded, understaffed, and at times populated more by resume builders than vigorous promoters of debating. Organizational efforts are extremely useful, of course, but they are only a small part of the total possibility. If “each one would teach one” we would have a vast expansion of debating even if the efforts failed most of the time. Each league, university, civic organization, school, or other group interested in debate can and should act on its own, not waiting for national or international organizations to do all of the work. Likewise, individual students, teachers, coaches, and trainers should not wait for the local or institutional organization to do the work to promote debate, because individual efforts and linkages can make all the difference. I have been asked how I have become involved with debating in many parts of the USA and the world. The answer is a relatively disappointing one for most people, as I was determined and creative. Keep opportunities to promote debate on your radar screen and the opportunities will arise. As you pursue them they will only multiply. I can think of several people who have proven how much their personal efforts and advocacy have meant to giving more students the opportunity to debate. We would be immensely smaller if any one of them had been deterred by an attitude that “someone else will do it.”

Learn and Teach in Tandem

New communities, new cultures, various age groups all have a tremendous opportunity to teach us. It seems like we learn most of the useful things about debate from each other. As we attempt to promote and teach debating, it is important for us to learn from those we work with. If you open yourself to such discovery it will be there. For example, when I travel to a new country I always study its history in advance, and then try and determine what role debating, in some form, had played in that nation or culture. This allowed me to prepare to learn from my visit itself. When I began working with urban debate leagues I tried to clear my mind of what the media may have told me about inner city youth and open myself to new discovery. Those discoveries were revealing and at times disturbing. Every

exchange between thinking human beings, to be optimal for both sides, needs to be grounded in a willingness to understand and take into account the ideas of the other. Every debate teaching and training opportunity needs to also be a learning opportunity. It is not just the students who are educated by the game of debate, but the judges, coaches, teachers, trainers, and audience are also educated if they are willing. Be willing.

The Playing Fields of Earth

I have shamelessly given a huge number of exhortation speeches about the wonders of debating. Spare me your patience as I recall one of my lines. When Napoleon was defeated it was said that he had not been defeated by the British on the battlefield of Waterloo, but rather on the playing fields of Eton. The games, teamwork, and strategy taught to English schoolboys had made all the difference on the battlefield. I hope for a day when the information battlefield of the future will be commanded by critical, compassionate, and visionary individuals who will win the day not so much because their spontaneous actions in the board room, at the ballot box, in the marketplace, or before a legislature, but because of their training and experience on the debate playing fields of planet Earth.

So, go forward in all your beliefs and prove to me that I am not mistaken in mine. You are the gamemaster.

*Imagine Earth restored to her real beauty,
Stately trees seem to brush the deep blue sky.
Clouds billow to form majestic peaks,
Songs of birds fill the air, creating symphony upon symphony.*

*The goddess is calling for the honoring of what she allows to be created
Through the core mystery of the blood.
Those who are on the planet are learning about love.*

-Lost Tribe, "Gamemaster," Tranceport CD

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